# Ellis Governance Brief

## How the work was governed in practice: the review loop with the platform's owners, the rules it produced, the gates every change passed, and the rhythm that kept it moving.

**As of** 8 Nov 2026 **Prepared by** Quincy Nkwain Ninying, Forward Deployed Engineer **Accountable** K.D. **Governance** A.M.

**Period** 19 to 30 Oct 2026

**21**
working rules adopted in seventeen days, each from a named decision

**47**
stories verified by the platform: 6 discovery, 40 capabilities and the Command Center

**76**
findings reviewed line by line by A.M.

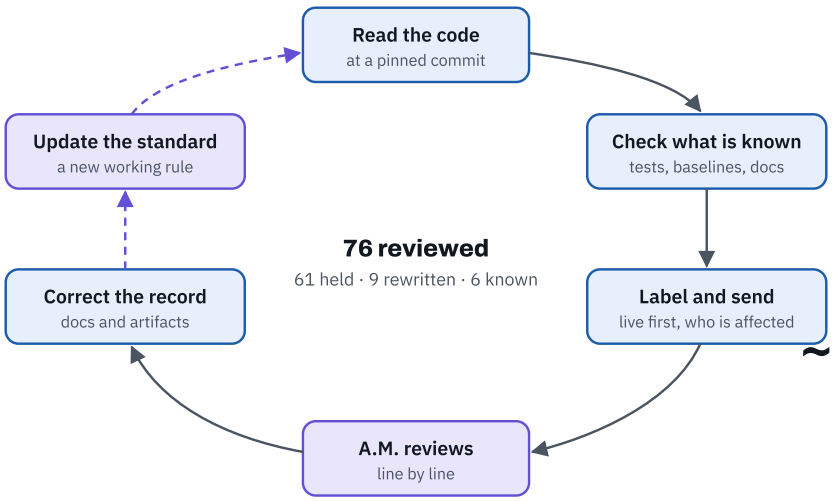
**9**
findings rewritten after review, each correction published

**0**
production actions taken by Ellis

THE REVIEW LOOP

### Every finding went round the same loop, and A.M.'s corrections changed the loop

Purple marks A.M.'s steps. The dashed return is the part that matters: a correction does not only fix one finding, it becomes a rule for every later one. The emailed loop ended on 30 Oct, when K.D. and A.M. decided defects are for Ellis to find; its rules carry over to what Ellis reports.




**8** working rules A.M. added through the loop: send security findings at once, write down the no-evidence rule, label every finding, check what is known first, how artifacts are published, ask the person when a finding turns on what reached them, write every verdict down per finding, and send pages as HTML or PDF

**~1 day** from sending a batch to A.M.'s line-by-line reply, for each batch reviewed so far

**14** findings fixed in the platform through five public pull requests, 3410, 3422, 3430, 3435 and 3439

RULES AS THEY WERE ADOPTED

## Twenty-one working rules, each from a named decision

Oldest first. Each one still applies to every later story and artifact.

K.D. accountable manager  A.M. governance  Q.N. Forward Deployed Engineer

19 Oct — **K.D. Build the agent first; measure before adding fixed steps**
Deterministic steps are added only where measurements show the agent is inefficient. Discovery story 1, version 2.

21 Oct — **K.D. Some work moves to the agent, some is shared, 23 decisions stay human**
The split every capability is built inside. Discovery story 3, version 2.

22 Oct — **K.D. Argue from the platform's own figures**
The system class was approved only once it was argued from the domain's real numbers, with sources. Discovery story 1, version 3.

22 Oct — **Q.N. The public repository holds approved deliverables only**
No credentials, customer data or private notes; discovery documents go in only in the version K.D. approved.

26 Oct — **K.D. Build with what exists and demo first**
Do not wait for every document's sign-off; A.M. refines after a demo. The three proposed tasks proceed in order.

26 Oct — **A.M. Security-shaped findings go straight away, K.D. copied**
Never batched with other findings.

27 Oct — **A.M. Write down "no evidence is not health" before building more**
One page for the next person who builds a monitor: a check says healthy only on recent, positive evidence.

27 Oct — **A.M. Label every finding, live risks first, with who is affected**
Live risk, latent, or reporting gap. Overstating one finding costs trust in the next.

27 Oct — **A.M. Check what is already known before calling it new**
Search the platform's tests, baselines and documents; cite a known item instead of pitching it.

27 Oct — **A.M. Artifacts are designed pages, kept in the repository as PDF**
Built as HTML with charts and conditional formatting, published as a claude.ai copy, and only the PDF committed.

27 Oct — **A.M. When a finding turns on what reached a person, ask the person**
The code showed the Sunday report could not run; A.M. confirmed it had not arrived in 45 days.

27 Oct — **A.M. A verdict that is not written down is not a verdict**
Every review outcome is recorded per finding, with its evidence, before it goes into a commit or a report.

28 Oct — **K.D. Checks become agent tools behind a gate and a broker**
Answers carry a verdict, a severity and row ids. Where capabilities overlap, A.M. decides, and holds stand until then.

28 Oct — **A.M.** **Send pages as HTML or PDF, not artifact links**
Anything sent to K.D. or A.M. is rendered from source.

30 Oct — **K.D. + A.M.** **Defects are for Ellis to find, not to be sent for fixing**
Defect emails stop. Defects appear in Ellis's output and write-ups.

30 Oct — **A.M.** **A release is a rung of autonomy, not a phase of work**
K.D. signs R0 to R2, A.M. signs R3 and above. Finishing a rung promotes nobody; a named person does, one step, on evidence.

2 Nov — **A.M.** **Verified work is never re-committed for credit**
Credit for repeated rung stories is A.M.'s backfill; a re-commit would hide what was rebuilt from what was only renamed.

2 Nov — **A.M.** **The public Command Center reads a committed snapshot**
The page stays public, calls no admin endpoint, and shows when the snapshot last changed.

4 Nov — **A.M.** **Overlapping capabilities merge into the check that already does the work**
Five fold into an existing check, three become one manager-access check, and two stay held until the gate and broker exist. 48 capabilities become 41.

4 Nov — **A.M.** **Every tool answers in one shape**
A verdict, a severity set only by K.D.'s table, and the rows behind it. Approved, and applied to every check the same day.

4 Nov — **A.M.** **Build the higher rungs now, each under its own rung id**
Keep building the sandbox rungs without waiting for the plan to change. Each commit names its board id (for example `platform.CAP.x.autonomy:R4`), never the base story id, so a verified result is never overwritten.

APPROVAL GATES

## Six gates, each with a named owner and a proof

### Discovery documents

OWNER · K.D.

A version is approved before it enters the repository.

Proof: each document's version history names the approved version

### Each capability

OWNER · THE PLATFORM

Built with tests, key rules broken on purpose, then confirmed by the platform reading the repository.

Proof: a verified state in the platform's progress record

### Each finding

OWNER · A.M.

Until 30 Oct, reviewed line by line; any correction goes into the capability write-up and the audit.

Proof: the audit's outcome column

### Each step up in autonomy

OWNER · K.D. TO R2, A.M. FROM R3

One level at a time, on evidence named in advance.

Proof: none taken yet; 16 next rungs are built in a sandbox and wait to be signed

### Any production action

OWNER · A PERSON

Merging, deploying or switching an agent is always done by a person.

Proof: the platform denies these to agents (executionPolicy.ts:33-42)

### Every push

OWNER · Q.N.

Nothing is committed or pushed without an explicit go, after a scan for anything private.

Proof: the repository's commit history

WORKING RHYTHM

## How information moves, and how fast

| WHAT | TO WHOM | WHEN |
|---|---|---|
| **Security-shaped finding** | A.M., K.D. copied | Same day, on its own |
| **Live risk** | A.M. and K.D. | Next message, listed first |
| **Reporting gaps and latent defects** | A.M. | Batched per capability |
| **Capability built and verified** | The platform, then the README | Each capability |
| **Progress, blockers and decisions needed** | K.D. | Weekly, Mondays 1:30 pm Central (proposed) |
| **Artifacts** | The repository (PDF) and claude.ai | Updated whenever a number they show changes |

From 30 Oct, the three finding rows carry what Ellis reports. Defects are no longer hunted and emailed by hand.

SOURCES

- Discovery stories 1 to 5: the approved versions and their version histories
- Colaberry Platform Reliability Audit: review outcomes for every finding
- No evidence is not health: the rule A.M. asked for
- Ellis AI Employee Charter: decision rights, hard limits and escalation